## The Surprisingly Unintelligible Narrative Surrounding EI

The role of emotions in cognition, their evolutionary origins and their distinction from instincts are topic of scientific inquiry. The conflict between emotion and rationality a historical discussion in philosophy and the common sense world of daily life. Mixing the various definitions and concepts between the various domains has created an unintelligible conversation. From the scientific perspective it is not even clear that emotions, instinct and “higher” brain functions can be separated. As a practical matter however the assumption that there is a thing called emotions has proven useful as a category of behavioral responses. What is not useful is confusing the assumptions with the reality. What follows applies correspondence cost frameworks to a domain where the cost of misrepresentation has been unusually high

The term Emotional Intelligence (EI) entered popular culture as a revolutionary idea: the claim that understanding and managing emotions matters as much as or more than traditional IQ for success in life, work, and relationships. Yet the public and professional conversation around EI is surprisingly unintelligible. Definitions shift depending on who is speaking, claims oscillate between cautious academic findings and breathless corporate hype, and the very concept seems to resist clear boundaries. What began as a promising psychological construct has become a Rorschach test onto which almost any self-help, management, or educational agenda can be projected.

The confusion starts at the origin. Psychologists Peter Salovey and John Mayer introduced EI in 1990 as an ability, a genuine form of intelligence involving perceiving, using, understanding, and managing emotions. Five years later, Daniel Goleman’s bestseller *Emotional Intelligence* reframed it into a broader mixed model that folded in personality traits, motivation, and social skills. The two approaches have never fully reconciled. Academic researchers largely defend the narrower ability model and insist on objective performance tests, while the business world prefers Goleman-style inventories that conveniently measure almost any desirable workplace behavior.

This definitional muddle is compounded by something deeper and more fundamental: the ethological understanding of emotions themselves remains dismal. Emotions are not the opposite of reason but a critical layer that makes advanced reason possible. To understand what that layer actually is, however, requires letting go of a warm-blooded prejudice that has quietly shaped the entire field. The popular conception of emotion treats it as a distinctly mammalian achievement, something that arrived on top of the cold, rigid instincts of simpler creatures. This is a distortion. What we call instinct in fish, reptiles, or insects, and what we call emotion in mammals and birds, are not categorically different systems but points on a continuum of compression sophistication. A fish defending its territory, a crow weighing risk before approaching food, a bee integrating multiple environmental signals to select a foraging route, all are performing rapid, lossy, context-sensitive signal integration that modulates behavior well beyond pure stimulus–response conditioning. The difference between this and mammalian emotion is one of richness, speed, and the degree of recursive self-revision, not of kind.

Each successive layer in this continuum represents more aggressive lossy compression. Across all animals, evolved behavioral systems cut out the vast majority of raw sensory information, constrained by evolutionary design. In simpler nervous systems, this compression is relatively fixed: the range of inputs that can modulate behavior is narrower, and recalibration is slower. As neural complexity increases through the elaborated limbic structures of mammals, the surprisingly sophisticated circuitry of corvids and cephalopods, the compression becomes more dynamic, faster, and more open to revision by experience and context. What we call emotion in mammals is this elaborated form: a particularly rich, rapid, and recursively self-revising compression heuristic that distills the state of the organism and its situation into actionable signals. It is not a new invention sitting atop older instincts; it is the same adaptive process running on more powerful hardware, yielding qualitatively richer outputs. In the complex environments that organisms must navigate, the richness of variability that emotions is directly tied to behavioral flexibility. Compression is necessary to turn that into action, physically or cognitively.

Andy Clark’s work on predictive processing offers a complementary picture of what this elaboration actually involves. On that account, the brain is not a passive receiver of sensory data but a prediction machine, constantly generating expectations and receiving back only the errors, the gaps between what was anticipated and what arrived. Perception itself is already deeply inferential. The mammalian upgrade, on this view, is not simply more processing power at the top; it is a richer, faster, more informationally dense interface between world and mind.

Crucially, these layers are not static modules stacked like bricks. They interact recursively: the more elaborated emotional signals modulate what lower-level reflexes make salient, while higher cognition can reinterpret and recalibrate those signals, which in turn reshape both reflexive drives and future emotional responses. The system is dynamic, interdependent, and constantly self-revising. A more accurate picture is not “emotion versus reason” (or even “instinct versus emotion versus reason”) but a single compression-and-modulation process that becomes progressively richer and more recursively self-revising as neural complexity increases. Consider a sudden loud noise: in any vertebrate, an immediate startle and freeze occurs at the reflexive level; in animals with more elaborated nervous systems, this is rapidly compressed into something like fear, a signal that mobilizes the body for action and narrows attention; in humans, higher cognition then reinterprets the sound in context (perhaps recognizing a friend slamming a door) and down-regulates that signal, which in turn updates the emotional heuristic for similar situations in the future. The same basic architecture runs across the animal kingdom; only the depth and speed of the recursive loop vary with the complexity of the nervous system.

This is not speculation. Neurologist Antonio Damasio’s work with patients who suffered damage to the orbitofrontal cortex leaving IQ and analytical reasoning intact while disrupting affective signaling showed that the result was not purer cognition but paralysis. One patient, known as EVR, could analyze decisions exhaustively and articulate pros and cons at length, yet became unable to commit to ordinary choices. What was missing was not intelligence but the emotional signal that normally terminates deliberation and drives action. The compression layer was not decorating the decision; it was completing it. Removing the emotion layer doesn't produce purer logos reasoning, it produces paralysis, exactly what you'd predict if emotion is the minimum-energy interface between uncertainty and action

The EI literature almost entirely ignores this architecture. Both the ability model and the mixed model treat emotions as pre-existing, relatively transparent psychological objects that a person can simply become “intelligent” about and, implicitly as the special property of warm-blooded creatures complex enough to have them. They rarely ask the prior ethological question of what emotions actually *are*: not a mammalian novelty, but an evolved compression mechanism present in varying degrees of elaboration across much of the animal kingdom, enabling rather than opposing flexible, abstract reasoning. The result is that people often talk past one another: one group is discussing a measurable cognitive ability, another is describing a desirable personality profile, and almost no one is grounding the discussion in how these recursive, layered mechanisms actually evolved to solve adaptive problems across hundreds of millions of years of nervous system evolution.

Measurement problems compound the muddle. Performance-based EI tests exist and show modest incremental validity beyond IQ and the Big Five personality traits, but they are time-consuming and rarely used outside research. Far more common are self-report questionnaires that suffer from obvious weaknesses people who lack emotional intelligence are ironically bad at rating their own. Meta-analyses repeatedly find that once you control for general intelligence and personality, EI adds only small predictive power for job performance or life outcomes. Yet popular literature and training programs continue to promise transformative results, creating a gap between evidence and expectation that borders on intellectual dishonesty especially when the underlying recursive architecture of emotion and cognition is left unexamined.

Commercial incentives have made the narrative even less coherent. EI became a multi-billion-dollar industry of certifications, workshops, and books. Consultants and HR departments love it because it sounds scientific while remaining pleasantly vague; executives like it because it shifts focus from hard skills and structural problems to “soft” personal development. In education, EI programs are sold as antidotes to bullying, anxiety, and underachievement, often with scant long-term data. The concept is elastic enough to justify almost any intervention while remaining difficult to falsify. The EI industry is, in its own way, a correspondence cost failure: a symbolic system that has drifted from the physical and evolutionary reality it claims to describe.

The unintelligibility of the EI story is therefore not accidental. It arises from the tension between a legitimate but modest psychological construct and the enormous demand for simple, marketable solutions to complex human problems built atop a still-immature scientific understanding of emotions as phylogenetically ancient, recursively elaborated compression processes rather than either opponents of reason or the exclusive property of warm-blooded creatures. We want EI to be both a real form of intelligence *and* a panacea that anyone can develop quickly. We want rigorous tests *and* quick self-assessments. We want it to predict success independently of IQ *and* to explain why high-IQ people sometimes fail. These contradictory desires, resting on an ethologically shallow foundation, produce a discourse that feels simultaneously over-hyped and under-specified.

A clearer narrative is possible. It would distinguish sharply between the narrow ability model (scientifically respectable but limited in scope) and the broader mixed models (practically useful but conceptually messy). More importantly, it would anchor the entire discussion in a serious ethological account: the compression-and-modulation process that we call emotion in mammals is a more elaborated version of adaptive mechanisms present across much of the animal kingdom, enabling rather than opposing flexible, abstract reasoning. Emotion and instinct are not separate systems, one warm-blooded and sophisticated, the other cold and mechanical but a continuum of the same underlying architecture. Only by recognizing that can EI be treated as a valuable set of skills and habits for reading, calibrating, and flexibly navigating that layered architecture rather than a mysterious superpower unique to creatures warm enough to feel. Until that happens, the conversation around emotional intelligence will remain surprisingly unintelligible, clear enough to sell, vague enough to survive scrutiny, and confusing enough that most people never notice the contradiction.

When we treat emotions as a “thing” separate from the rest of the cognitive structure rather than a necessary part of a process we get distortion. Both mythos and logos are necessary ways to navigate uncertainty depending on context. This is just one of a series of documents. Refer to the master index for an overview.

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